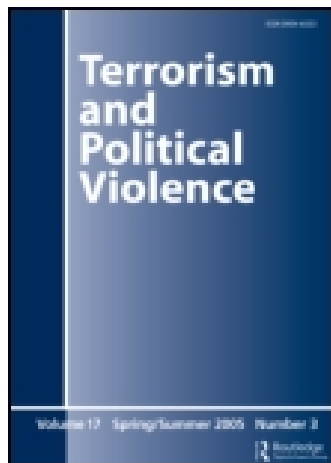


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Clark McCauley and Sophia Moskalenko. Friction: How Radicalization Happens to Them and Us

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Richelson's study is well-informed and provides the reader with an insider's view of the persons and issues involved in NEST. It will be of particular interest to students of nuclear surety and nuclear terrorism.

Clark McCauley and Sophia Moskalenko. *Friction: How Radicalization Happens to Them and Us*. Oxford, UK: Oxford University Press, 2011. 240 pp., \$35.00 hardcover. ISBN: 978-0-19-974743-6.

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Clark McCauley and Sophia Moskalenko's *Friction: How Radicalization Happens to Them and Us* is a thought-provoking book on the mechanisms of radicalization within terrorist groups. *Friction* is both intriguing and very readable, written in a captivating style that balances theoretical and empirical insights from social psychology with interesting examples and case studies. The authors identify twelve mechanisms of radicalization which they divide into three larger sections: (a) individual, (b) group, and (c) mass radicalization. Chapters are prefaced with related examples of terrorist personae from the 19th century Russian Anarchist terror group, *Narodnaya Volya* (The People's Will) before the presentation of theoretical discussion, and then typically conclude with a relevant contemporary terrorist example as contrast.

Individual Radicalization

In their first section, McCauley and Moskalenko identify six mechanisms of individual radicalization. Through *personal grievances*, the terrorist is radicalized due to perceived injustices against themselves or those close to them. *Group grievance* focuses on the rare cases of self-radicalization of "lone wolf" terrorists who identify with a larger group through a process of mixing both political and personal grievances. *Slippery slopes* explores the process of radicalization through engaging in repeated small actions that increase commitment. *Love* argues that affective relationships "for someone already radicalized can move an individual towards radicalization" (p. 49). *Risk and Status* takes a positivist approach to explaining radicalization by arguing that disenfranchised, young and marginalized people are more likely to engage in risky behaviour to achieve status due to evolutionary psychology (reproductive success is tied to social status) and higher levels of testosterone (serving as a biological driver for status seeking). Lastly, the chapter devoted to *unfreezing* suggests that sustaining value judgments depends on having an interpersonal network of others who reinforce those values.

Group Radicalization

The second section is devoted to mechanisms of radicalization within groups. It begins with *group polarization*, which argues that political discussion in groups leads to increased agreement about the opinion at issue. When presented with *group*

competition by a common threat, terrorist groups respond with increased cohesion, idealization of in-group values, and escalation. Lastly, *group isolation* explores the coercive power that totalistic groups have over individual members, giving primacy to group consensus over personal opinions.

Mass Radicalization

The final section covers the mechanisms of radicalization among the masses. McCauley and Moskalenko argue that terrorist groups engage in *jujitsu politics*, where they manipulate violent counter-responses in order to generate sympathy and support for the terrorists among the masses. *Hatred* is hinged on the perception of “bad essence” in another group, that there is an immutable characteristic that differentiates “them” from “us.” Lastly, the authors argue that *martyrdom* is a constructed, political tool used by terrorists to increase motivation for sacrifice among group members and the public at large.

Friction concludes with two final chapters. The second-to-last chapter is devoted to applying the twelve mechanisms of radicalization to the case study of Osama bin Laden. The final chapter presents a summary of different unanswered questions and interesting avenues for further research. Perhaps the most memorable assertion made by the authors is found in the conclusion, where they argue that “radicalization emerges in a relationship, in the friction of intergroup competition that heats both sides” (p. 223). The authors argue that in order to properly understand radicalization, research should pay equal attention to how the dynamics of terrorist conflict not only radicalize “them,” but how it radicalizes “us” and our responses to terrorism. This is a unique and telling insight which is bound to influence future research into terrorist radicalization.

Conclusion

While many of the mechanisms of radicalization have been raised elsewhere in the wider literature on the psychology of terrorism, *Friction* manages to present them in a concise and highly readable book. *Friction*’s greatest strength also happens to be its greatest weakness: in its attempt to be accessible and engaging, it fails to rigorously reference the wider academic literature on the psychology of terrorism. Citations are kept to a minimum and aside from brief “further reading” sections at the end of each chapter, the bibliography is conspicuously absent. *Friction* will be of interest to scholars, students, and general readers who are interested in a pleasurable, yet informative analysis of the process of radicalization and terrorist groups.